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ENG 107

23rd March 2023

Why Is *Heartstopper* Popular?

Heartstopper is a European web series that stole the heart of many people, mainly the people belonging to LGBTQ+ community and who support them. This series is Netflix adaption of Alice Oseman's best-selling graphic novel *Heartstopper*. "*Heartstopper* has racked up one improbable success after another since it began life in 2016, as a black-and-white webcomic by Alice Oseman. The reception to the comic, which has received more than 52 million views, inspired Oseman to crowd-fund and self-publish a "*Heartstopper*" graphic novel in 2018, which drew the attention of a publisher in 2019. Three more volumes and a coloring book have followed, together selling more than one million copies. The live-action adaptation has remained among Netflix's most-watched English-language shows since it premiered in late April" (Zornosa).

Heartstopper, released in 2022, instantly gained popularity and became a fan favorite. "The debut season of *Heartstopper*, an LGBTQ- romance story between two high school boys, has a 100% on Rotten Tomatoes, a rarity for Netflix scripted series these days, but also a 98% audience score with over 1800 reviews in. That's deeply impressive given the context of where we usually see those numbers (fan favorite Marvel series on Disney Plus, for instance, might have a 92-94% audience score)" (Tassi). It is also streamed a lot in many countries. "Fans spent over 53 million hours watching the series within its first three weeks on Netflix, resulting in it being on the platform's top 10 list for television shows in 54 countries" (Keswani).

Heartstopper takes us through the journey of two teenage boys, Charlie Spring (Joe Locke) and Nick Nelson (Kit Connor), falling in love. Charlie is a shy gay boy who is struggling with the aftermath of being outed against his will, while Nick is a rugby player who is open minded and understanding. The story also contains romance between friends of Nick and Charlie.

The way Oseman draws the characters in her graphic novel is very simple and attractive. The simplicity of them makes one feel connected to them. There are subtle ways she implies the romance between people, for example, she drew leaves whenever there is a spark between Charlie and Nick. Those little details are pleasant to watch. The show does a really good job of animating those details. “The most conspicuous element is the incorporation of 2-D animation. The moments are spare and subtle — snow falling around Nick and Charlie or leaves swirling around friends, a recurring visual in the comic. But based on the abundant feedback online, viewers noticed and approved” (Zornosa).

The series captures all the iconic moments in the comic which made the fans of the comic very happy. “A particularly striking thing about the Netflix series, which was created and written by Oseman, is the degree to which it faithfully recreates the comic onscreen, with actors who closely resemble the main characters and many shots that match the images from the source material” (Zornosa). The actors are new, for most of them *heartstopper* is their first series. “With the lead cast coming to *Heartstopper* relatively fresh faced it means the audience has no major preconceptions about who they are and how they will act on screen. As such, their performances feel very real, and it isn’t difficult to see them as their characters, rather than getting them confused with other roles they have played” (Wiggan). The actors are also around the same age as characters. Joe Locke and Kit Connor who played the roles of Charlie and Nick (main characters) were around 17 and 16 years respectively when filming (IMDB) and Joe Locke is openly gay (Pham) which makes it easier for the actors to bring the

character to life and making the audience feel connected and represented. As Joe Locke (who is 18) said in an interview with GQ, “We’re all still teenagers, so we’re acting these feelings that feel really real and recent for all of us” (Girardot).

The soundtrack used in the show attracted a lot of audience too. “While both the story and the characters/actors are a big part of *Heartstopper*’s success, it’s important to take a moment to highlight the show’s soundtrack. The songs used throughout the show have been expertly picked to ensure they not only match the tone of the series, but also reflect the emotions and feelings of the characters too” (Wiggan).

The timing also played an important role “The timing of its release also provides a beacon of hope that many of us desperately needed. With the passing of the “Don’t Say Gay” Bill in Florida, and the UK government refusing to include trans people in the ban on conversion therapy, being LGBTQ+ has started to feel like more of an uphill battle in recent years” (Hovey).

Among the many shows that misses the crucial part of representation, *Heartstopper* stands out due to its accurate depiction. “Most people love a feel-good TV show, especially when they can see themselves represented on screen. Netflix’s *Heartstopper* does just that with its wide variety of characters who identify as LGBTQ+ (lesbian, gay, bisexual, transgender, questioning/queer and others such as pansexual and two-spirit)” (DeRoy-Olson).

Heartstopper not only represents homosexuals but also transgenders, bisexuals, Asians, and blacks which makes it appealing to a large number of audiences. “*Heartstopper* depicts an honest queer high school experience through its multiple LGBTQ voices on set, and in particular queer voices of color too. This includes Elle Argent, a Black transgender girl who is dealing with switching from an all-boys school to an all-girls school, and Tara, a

Black lesbian dating her best friend, Darcy.” (Innecco and Charon). The role of Elle’s love interest is played by Will Gao who is half Chinese and half English. This caused a noticeable impact on people from Asian countries. Will mentioned about this in an interview with VGL, “There’s a big support in China. The fans in China and the Philippines feel represented, and that’s cool that they can have someone to relate to” (Gotham).

In many series, bisexuals are depicted negatively but Alice Oseman (author of *heartstopper*) did it differently. Nick, the love interest of the protagonist, struggles with his identity because he, who liked girls before and still likes girls is also developing a crush on the protagonist who is a boy. This attraction towards a boy confuses him and he gets scared. Later, he finds out that there is a sexual orientation that makes one attracted to both boys and girls, that is, bisexuality. The way Oseman takes us through the journey of Nick figuring out his sexuality is heart-warming. Oseman integrates the problematic assumption of the sexuality binary but allows the characters to combat it in a way that legitimizes bisexuality through positive peer reaction” (Allen).

As we go on Twitter, Reddit, or Facebook, we can see how many people find their stories in a variety of characters in a show. The more people can find their stories, the more popular a show becomes. Doug Girardot’s is one of the many stories about how they found themselves in Nick and Charlie from *heartstopper*,

Considering the slight melancholy that watching “*Heartstopper*” made me feel (despite my happiness for the characters), why couldn’t I take my eyes away? The answer, I’ve come to realize, is that for the first time in my life, I felt seen for all of who I am. I’m crying as I write this, and I can tell the tears are coming from God. I see myself in Charlie’s social awkwardness, his tendency to talk deprecatingly about himself, his confusion at having one foot in the

world of the “cool kids” even while remaining friends with people on the social peripheries of the high-school landscape. And I see myself in Nick as he presents a straight-acting exterior that belies his deepest, most human yearnings (Girardot).

There is a scene in the show where Nick, due to his growing feelings towards Charlie, takes one of the quizzes available on google that shows whether a person is homosexual, when he gets the results and realizes that he might be attracted to guys, he cries. The fear he felt for possibly being gay and the joy he felt for loving someone, the bittersweet emotions he was feeling, everything was expressed greatly by the actor which made the audience who are in the same situation as him feel connected and represented.

There are many scenes like this in the show, like, the scene where Nick’s mother supported him when he came out, this gives hope to people who are looking for validation from their parents. Esme is one of the people who came out using this scene and then tweeted about it. “Just came out as queer to my parents using nicks coming out scene in the show, feeling emotional rn” (Kiley). These types of scenes which resonate with real-life situations of some of the people makes the series appreciable.

The series not only resonates with younger generation but also with older ones. Erik Van Dam, 41, talks about a scene which he relates to,

When Nick explains to his long-time friend Imogen, who has a crush on him, why he doesn’t want to go on a date. Sitting on a park bench together with Nick’s dog, he shares: “Do you ever feel like you’re only doing things because everyone else is? And you’re scared to change or do something that might confuse or surprise people? Your real personality has been, like, buried inside you for a really long time?” Erik felt exactly the same way. “I’ve never heard

anyone describe my feelings so perfectly,” he said. Erik put his feelings about coming out behind him in order to move on, but that doesn’t mean that he’d processed them. Until he saw his story told on screen in this way, he wasn’t aware that he needed to heal (Katz).

Heartstopper inspired many people with the positive outlook it has. It caused cultural changes and influenced political sphere in some countries. The impact it caused on political sphere of United Kingdom is the most evident.

On June 13, Member of Parliament Luke Pollard used the show to support a petition to include transgender people in Prime Minister Boris Johnson’s conversion therapy ban. In the House of Commons, he acknowledged how the show’s “visibility, that legitimacy, has saved lives,” and commended it for “[drawing people] together by a broad hug, not with a big stick.” He also acknowledged how Finney’s role as Elle, a trans woman of color, “not only inspired me, it’s inspired young trans people across the world.” This mention demonstrates how television shows like "*Heartstopper*" can contribute to culture and actual policy (Keswani).

For many people (mainly the people belonging to the LGBTQ community) *Heartstopper* is not just a show but a celebration, it changed their lives and gave hope that things could be better. The cast, story, soundtrack, and heart-warming and positive scenes, everything that made the show popular had and still have a profound effect on people. It is happy news for fans of the show that Netflix renewed it for two more seasons. “We were overjoyed with the global reaction to *Heartstopper* and can’t wait to continue the story with two more seasons. Watch this space!” (Thao). Hopefully, *heartstopper* can reach every person who needs it.

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